Zachary Tan

Barcarolle for the Blind

Ends of lives are always so sudden, but it's the kind of sudden that makes you think, "Oh, so that's how it is." Then there's the funeral: the second-worst thing about death. We dress up your carcass and make it all lovely-charming for your closest friends and family, and those that you never knew existed. We hang you up on display like a cut of prime rib at the butchers, then gather around to appraise your value.

"Two days of grieving and one month of thought," a shopper states firmly.

"One month?!" another exclaims with incredulity. "I'd say it's worth at most two weeks."

"You're all heartless!" your mother cries. "I would think she's worth at least two months of thought to you all!" She pauses to catch her breath. "To me, she's worth a week of depression, a month of grieving, and five years of thought."

She has a smug, self-satisfied smile on her face, like she thinks she's better than everyone else. Turning to me, a predatory glint in her eyes, she asks, "What do you think? As her wife-"

"Partner," I say.

"Whatever." She rolls her eyes. "As her wife, what is she worth to you?"

…

I forget where I am in the eulogy, and the words on the page in front of me start to crawl around like maggots in rotting flesh. Not wanting to prolong this moment even a second longer, I try to find an end.

"She was—" stupid and selfish "—selfless and kind, quiet and caring,—" and spoiled and docile "—and the best partner I could have ever asked for." I stop, but it still doesn't feel final.

“When we got married, we swore to love ‘until death do us part,’ so now I swear, before many of the same faces, to love her still until death reunites us.”

I don’t process any of the words I say as they sink into the air in front of me. The silence sets me adrift in that same ocean of insecurities I was in when we said our vows. But this time, you’re not there to rescue me.

…

Max greets me as I walk through the door. His cold tongue on my leg snaps me out of the haze I did not remember entering. The rhythmic clacks of his nails against the hardwood floor are therapeutic and make me look around, expecting to see you lying on the sofa, or sitting at the dining table, or at the piano, head cocked towards the front door. A wave of disappointment crashes into me when I am met with the stillness of a lifeless apartment.

Max licks my leg again, and I take a deep breath, softly smiling at him. I inch towards the couch, unwilling to disturb the silence in the air, and collapse into your favorite corner next to the window. Instead of gently flopping onto you like usual, I fall farther than usual, and my chin crashes into the bead eyes of your hatefully blue, disgustingly worn, stuffed penguin. I wince, then wrap my arms and legs around it, squeezing as hard as I can while forcing my eyes shut. The stench of your perfume and body odor still clings to that penguin, and I wonder how many washes it will take to get them out.

I hear Max lay on the floor next to me, and habitually stick my hand out to greet him. Grasping only air, for a moment I believe he too is gone, and have a moment of panic before finally feeling his comforting, fluffy fur. I gently run my hand up and down his back as I resist the urge to squeeze with all my might. Usually, you would wrap your arms around me so I feel safe and secure, and gently pat my back, lulling me into a drowsy daze. Usually, this is when you

ask about my day, then, while I gather my thoughts to respond to you, talk about yours: the chirping of the birds, the brief snippets of conversation you overheard through the open window, the sounds of the people and cars passing below, and the lives you imagined for each of them. Instead, I hear Max's soft breathing. I hear my soft breathing. And I hear the hum of the world moving around me.

…

Time flows like water, and I am afloat in my sea of memories. The day we first met, we bonded over having both played Tchaikovsky's June at the piano recital. We both had a similar interpretation: a small boat gently rocking in a serene lake. But where you saw moving forward, I saw it stationary. The days we collapsed on top of each other on the floor of your dorm, both laughing and complaining about our classes and professors. The day you proposed at that fancy restaurant, playing that very song, then dropping to your knee. The days we both returned exhausted from work, lying on the couch in comfortable silence. The day your eyes finally fully clouded over. The day you fell on the stairs outside our apartment. The day we received Max. The days we argued. The day you left.

I cycle through feeding Max, aimlessly wandering around the apartment, and lying on the couch. I regret going to that funeral, and I hate how I had to lie through my teeth to avoid spilling how disgustingly selfish you are for leaving me here all alone. I also hate how everyone seemed so disingenuous as they came up to me and apologized for my loss, like it was somehow their fault.

As usual, I sit up when I can't force out any more anger and slowly shuffle around the living room. I try to stub my toe on every corner and piece of furniture that sticks out: the piano, the counter, the wall corner, the couch. Something stops me each time, and I wonder why I can't

be more like you. My inability to hurt myself maddens me. The clacking of Max's nails reminds me I am not alone, and it seems he has mistaken me for you because he follows me everywhere.

I look out the window for the first time since the eulogy. I had shut the ever-open windows a week after I heard of your death because the sounds of the city kept reminding me of you. As I stare down on the busy people and cars moving to and fro, I notice a tiny nest on the balcony nestled between your potted mint plant and the stone brick wall. The sad pile of twigs stands out against the black metal bars, but blends in with the mint leaves, partially shielding them from view.

A bird roosts at the edge of the plants. It is greyish-brown with specks of black on its wings and long tail feathers that flow together, making its body seem smooth and unbroken. It notices me through the window and cocks its head, turning one eye towards me. Its eye is pitch black, but not in a malicious sort of way; it's pitch black in the way the dark of night is. Flecks of light dance in its eyes like stars in the sky.

…

Max left me for you. I guess he couldn't bear to leave you alone for even a month. Or he couldn't bear to stay with me any longer, as I imagine you did. I find him on the floor in front of the door when I get home from work. He doesn't greet me, and he doesn't move his head or twitch his ears when I call his name. He just lies next to the couch, closed eyes pointed towards the door, utterly deaf to the world. A deep breath catches in my chest as I struggle to breathe and rein in my unruly thoughts. Surely he is just sleeping. In a softer voice, I call his name again, hoping and hoping that he will respond. I am drowning in silence.

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The vet stares down at his clipboard as he speaks at me.

"I'm very sorry for your loss," the vet says. "There's no sign of injury or distress, so it looks like he passed on peacefully of old age."

He pauses, still not looking at me.

"He lived a long life. Thirteen years is a good age for a German Shepard," he continues. "We can take care of arrangements for you, if you'd like."

"Take care?" I ask. "How?"

"We can arrange cremation," he says. "Private or communal, depending on your preference. Of course, you get to keep the ashes."

There's a knowing look in his eyes, like he knows you are dead. Like, there's no way a seeing person like me would keep such an old seeing eye dog for any other reason.

I opt to have Max's ashes mailed to me rather than pick them up. I can't stomach returning to that place again, all alone.

…

Waiting is agony, and during that time, I again ask for time off work. But, unlike with you, I am denied. It seems human lives are worth more than a dog's. While I wait, I decide it is time to finally unmute my phone. The moment I do so, I am hit with a flood of notifications: texts and missed calls from our friends, voicemails, and emails.

I spend days thinking, and responding, and lying through my fingers, saying "I'm okay" and "Please don't worry about me." The most sickening part of it all is having to thank them for their condolences. It feels less like comfort and more like everyone taking turns touching something that was never theirs to begin with. Not that you were mine anyway, you were only ever beholden to yourself. And that was part of the problem.

When Max's ashes arrived, I wanted to take him to the same lake I took you, but I lacked the motivation to leave the apartment, and left him on top of the piano. Instead, I was trapped in my own home, buried in silence, clinging to a dirty old penguin.

…

I learned that the bird nesting on the balcony is called a mourning dove. It seemed both ironic and like fate, so I spent my days paying extra attention to it. I watched as the dove flew in and out of the nest, leaving in quick, uncertain bursts and returning just as suddenly. When it was gone, I would stare at the nest, and the three eggs clustered in the middle of it. When it was back, I lost myself in the sea of greyish-brown that was its back. It must have familiarized itself with my gaze, as it startled less and less.

I learned that mourning doves mate for life, but I never saw a second dove. I assumed it was just like me. Or maybe it was just like you.

Whenever it saw me through the window, it tilted its head the same as when you did whenever I came home: with anticipation and slight trepidation, like you were trying to decide whether I was real or imaginary. You would softly coo out my name in a way that drained all the tension out of my body. I always wondered what would happen if I didn't respond. If I pretended like it wasn't me, would you continue to preen your feathers like this mourning dove? Would you turn your head and resume your melancholic stare at the outside world? That same stare you sometimes made when you thought I wasn't looking? No, you would probably pout with mock anger because Max's propelling tail and skittering towards me would instantly give me away.

It sometimes looked at me the exact same way you sometimes looked at me: with a gaze that was half confusion, half resignation. Not understanding me, and realizing there was nothing you could say to change my mind.

…

“Don’t you think you’re being a bit selfish?” it asks, shuffling its wings.

“What do you mean? Everything I do is all for you,” I say.

It grimaces, pursing its beak.

“I just want you to live long and be happy,” I plead. “I know you might not be happy now, but who knows what the future will bring? Don’t you want to see that future together with me?”

It tilts its head and squints at me.

“Even so, isn’t that just what you want?” it asks. “You want me to be happy, but have you thought about what I want? What if I don’t think I can be happy… or don’t want to be happy?”

“You can’t be happy if you’re dead,” I argue.

“Well, I can’t be sad either.” It scoffs. “Actually, I think it's more selfish that you’re trying to push me in the direction that you want… to force your own opinion on me.” It shuffles around and turns its whole body to face me. “How long do you want me to suffer for? I already… I already waited… just like you asked. I waited for ten years for things to get better, but they never did. Even though, year after year, you promised it would… I just couldn’t bear to see you suffering anymore for my sake. I know how much of a drain supporting me is. Don’t think that just because I can’t see you, I don’t know what you’re thinking. I could hear how much suffering I was causing you. And, I know you. I know you would never say or do anything.” She pauses, then crinkles her eyes the same way you did before telling a joke. “Because you’re a coward,” she says in a playfully half-serious tone.

“But…” My argument dies in my throat. I know she is telling the truth. We’ve had this same conversation countless times before, and it always ended in her acquiescence. But this time, my usual arguments feel hollow and insincere.

“But what?” There’s a sharp trill in her voice, the type of sound that can only come from a bird parroting human speech. “What about everyone else? Think about how they would feel? I did think about how everyone felt. I ignored how I felt and listened to everyone else. For ten years, I put up with myself and lived for others, and where did that lead me?” It spread its wings, puffing itself up and raising its head. “Absolutely nowhere! Why should someone else’s grief outweigh my constant pain? Also, it’s not like they’ll be thinking about me in ten years anyway.” She stares into my eyes and lowers her voice. “Just see me for who and what I actually am. Please just see that I am unhappy. Please, just let me be free.”

Her words claw at my conscience and shred it to ribbons. Usually, I argue and push back with my feelings, the feelings of the people around her. I beg her to get help while squeezing next to her on the couch, wrapping my arms around her to feel her warmth and listening to her heartbeat. Usually, she sighs then wordlessly and slowly returns my embrace. But maybe there’s too much truth for me this time.

“But… But what about me? I’ll be thinking about you,” I say in the smallest voice I can muster. I pray that you don’t hear me.

You fold your wings and lower your head, turning to stare down on the faceless people passing below.

You croak out in a minuscule voice, “Sorry.”

…

I go to the pet store to buy a large bird cage and struggle to bring it back to the apartment, ignoring the stares and whispers around me. When I finally enter the apartment, I'm drenched in sweat from the July heat and lugging a large box halfway across the city. I collapse on the floor from both physical and mental exhaustion, and I silently laugh at myself. Lying on the ground, I wait for Max to run over to me and cover my face in kisses, but instead of his furry face, I see the lights spinning above me like stars in the sky.

Once I catch my breath, I begin setting up the bird cage between the sofa and the window. I make sure to set it as close to the window as I can, so she can get as much sunlight as she usually does.

It is nearly sunset when I finish building the cage and rearranging the furniture. I peek out the window at your nest, but don't see you. Instead, three white and unblemished eggs shine in the middle of the sorry pile of sticks. Strange. Usually, you would be back by now. I feel something sinking in my chest. It is cold and heavy. I wait by the window until the sun crests the concrete the next morning, but you still don't return.

"You're late." I delude myself with a half-laugh.

I wait all of the next day, but as Monday approaches, I begin to lose hope. Have you abandoned me again? No, I'm being selfish. I stare at the three presumably dead eggs, abandoned. What does it even mean to be abandoned? Can you abandon something that's already dead? I decide to leave the eggs outside.

Recollecting myself, I stare at the now-useless cage clogging up the corner of the living room. I decided to leave it up in case you decide to come back.

…

There's a rat in the apartment. Certainly, the state of the apartment had seen better days, but I liked to believe I kept it presentable, at least to the touch. It's on the carpet beside the couch's armrest, right between the two large stains from when you spilled your drinks. I told you I had gotten them out after an hour of vigorous scrubbing, but I had lied. It seems confused, caught between two unknown entities.

You've come back.

I crouch as close to the floor as I can and carefully slither my way towards where the rat is. Its nose twitches, just like yours did whenever I was cooking something in the kitchen, a light smile on your face. Its head cocks, and it stares at me. We both freeze, and I have a moment of 'what am I even doing,' before I strike. I lunge forward and grab the rat with my left hand, but my momentum carries me past the stains and couch and headfirst into the wall. There's a hollow thunk as my head and shoulders collide with it. My body rolls up the wall, then I slowly slide down.

You squirm in my hand, and I feel your teeth break skin, snapping me out of my daze. I quickly secure you with both hands, then, fighting the pain radiating through my body, make my way to the bird cage and place you inside. The lock clicks shut.

I stand before the cage panting, then after a moment of thought, I begin dragging it from next to the window to beside the piano and out of the sun. You are squeaking viciously as you run around and around the bird cage, trying to find a place to hide.

…

I notice the rat staring at the piano, and smile.

"I wish I could play our favorite song, but sadly, I forgot how to," I tell it. "I really don't think I can relearn it just yet, but if you want, I can find a recording and play it for you?"

The rat remains silent, but its eyes never leave the piano. I walk over and aggressively blow off the layer of dust that has collected on the top of it. The dust makes a perfect counterattack, as seemingly all of it manages to find a way into my face and eyes. Blinded, I stagger towards the kitchen sink to wash it all out, but misremember the distance and instead run straight into the kitchen counter. A wave of helplessness washes over me as I bonelessly fold over. A hollow thud sounds as my nose and forehead collide with the granite countertop.

I stay there for a moment, surrounded by darkness, my heavy breathing, the hum of the air conditioner, the throbbing of my pelvis and face, and the agitated squeaking of a disturbed rat behind me.

I feel like I could force my eyes open a crack, just enough to find my way around the counter and to the sink, but something stops me. Ignoring the tears streaming down my face and my throbbing head and nose, I use my hands to feel the end of the counter and carefully move around it. I try to remember if I had left anything on the floor, but I can't, so I just pray the path is clear. I feel out the space ahead with each foot before gingerly placing it down to take my next step. My hands grip the edge of the counter as I slowly shuffle around it. Each time, my hand or foot explores a new space, I keep expecting something to be there, but fortunately, there is nothing, and I make it to the sink without any further mishaps.

After cleaning out my face and running my eyes under water for a torturously long time, I hesitantly open them, and am met with a hazy, all-too-bright image of the drab apartment. I rapidly blink to clear my eyes as everything shifts into focus.

The rat had stopped squeaking at some point while I was running my eyes under the faucet, and seems to have settled down in the corner of the cage farthest away from me and the

piano. Its body, squished into the corner, is still pointed towards the piano, so I know what it still wants. I smile.

I open my phone, greeted by two silhouettes outlined by a dark image of a lake, and scroll through my voice memos. Eventually, reaching one from thirteen years ago, I press play. I hear your voice say, “Tchaikovsky’s June: Barcarolle,” then the apartment is drowned in music. I was lucky that one of your friends had recorded when you proposed to me, or else I wouldn’t have this. You never liked playing in public, claiming you played for yourself, and not for others. When I asked you, “What about me?” you sheepishly replied, “And you.”

I hear the soft clinking of utensils in the background and the chatter of the other guests at the restaurant get drowned out as the sound of a Steinway grand piano bleeds through the speakers and fills the room with its soft yet powerful voice. A stark contrast to our upright Young Chang.

You and I listen as the melody rocks back and forth like a little boat adrift in a lake. The higher notes twinkle above the song, as tiny waves echo around us. The recording ends in gentle silence, and I cut it off right before the perfunctory applause. You later told me that you were supposed to read the connected poem, but were too nervous and forgot to do so. However, we had both read and repeated it enough times to memorize it, probably multiple times over. You gushed over how romantic it was, and how much you wanted to experience it yourself, and I’m glad I took you to that lake before your sight left you.

Even after you had gone blind, you still played that song. It was one of the few songs that you made an active effort to maintain, and it wasn’t until you were sent to a psychiatric ward for several weeks that you began to forget bits and pieces of it. Your fingers began fumbling over the

keys, and you grew more hesitant, afraid of hitting a wrong note. Over the course of a year, you slowly forgot tiny chunks until all you remembered was the beginning, and the poem:

Let us go to the shore;

there the waves will kiss our feet.

With mysterious sadness

the stars will shine down on us.

…

You died nearly a year later. I don't know how long you had lived before you came to me, but I learned that rats usually live for around two years. So, you had probably spent about half of your life with me, just like your human form did. I decide to cremate you for a third time and place the small wooden box you come back in next to Max's on top of the piano. Next to each other, there is nearly no difference other than size and the light layer of dust covering Max's box. I never did work up the courage to reunite you and Max at the lake.

I take a deep breath. Then, stuffing both boxes into my pocket, I head out.

I drive in silence, apart from the GPS shouting at me every other minute, and arrive at the lake just before dusk. I search for the spot on the shore with the massive stump we had rested our canoe against when I first brought you here, and every time after that. By the time I find it, it is nearly dark, the sun's red eye just barely visible over the horizon.

I look up and take in the dazzling stars and bright moon. They seem both too far away to be real, but also close enough for me to grab one and take it home.

I take Max's box out of my pocket and pry it open. Inside is a small plastic bag with his ashes. I take off my shoes and tear the bag open. Small puffs of smoke escape, as if he is begging to be free.

"In a minute," I coo at him.

The ashes settle down.

His eyes shine brightly up at me, and I can see him lying down in the bag, tail flopping back and forth like a metronome.

I sluggishly walk into the cold water, the lake gently lapping at my feet, and quickly turn the bag upside down. Max rushes out, like he does when he sees me come home. He dissolves into the receding tide, running away to meet you. As I did with your ashes, I shake the bag, feeling sick all the while. I need to make sure all of him meets with all of you. It's dark out there, so you're going to need Max more than I do.

I stuff the empty bag back into my pocket and take out the other box. This time, there are far fewer ashes in the bag, and I can barely make out the shape of a rat against the dark water below me. I debate for a brief moment, not opening the bag, but I'm not as selfish as you.

All of you comes out in one small cloud that wafts for a moment in the air, then settles down onto the gentle waves. I close my eyes because I can't bear to see you leave for a second time. I take a step back and return the bag to my pocket. Then, I slowly lie down on the wet sand. I feel the waves gently lapping at my feet, and I imagine you are kissing me. I imagine you are happy.

I open my eyes.

The stars shine above me with mysterious sadness.